

IN CONTEXT

Russian serfdom

Russia's peasants had been exploited for centuries before a system of full serfdom was adopted in the 1600s—according to which, landowners took control of those who worked their land. Rules were often breached, but serfs could not be bought or sold independent of the land. They were bonded to their owners for life in return for tenancy of small plots of land. The system delivered social stability, economic stagnation, and appalling injustice. All Russian serfs were finally emancipated in 1861, following an edict issued by Czar Alexander II, which led to a rapid improvement in the Russian economy.



ABOLITION OF SERFDOM IN RUSSIA, ALFONS
MARIA MUCHA, 1914

The illegitimate son of an aging Armenian prince, Luka